

Read the board before choosing a move

Foundations

THE IDEA

A position is a set of relationships, not a collection of pieces. Start with whose turn it is, king safety, material, and direct threats. A beautiful plan is irrelevant if a queen is hanging now.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Suppose your opponent moves a bishop onto the same diagonal as your queen. Before continuing a pawn attack, trace that diagonal and identify every blocker. The bishop may be attacking the queen immediately or preparing a discovered attack.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Name four things to check after an unfamiliar opponent move.

ANSWER AND REASONING

Check direct checks, captures, threats, and newly opened lines. Then compare the resulting position with your plan. You need not abandon the plan unless the position gives a concrete reason.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Ask what changed before asking what you want.